

AT LAST

And now the deception of Venith was made clear. He would not help Aster create evil in the world. He would not be the savior that Serna saw in him. He would not protect Terra from the cruelty of mankind. He would not teach the world how to wield Entropy's magic. He cared not for the balance of the world he promised to restore to Fuera. Now the other Gods would see his betrayal met with fury.

But it was far, far too late. First, he used Fuera's power to extend his life forever and ascend as a New God. Then, he threw the world into chaos.

For how can the most powerful wizards cast away the demons if their wands do not work, if the very magic they trust warps and twists beneath their fingers? How can the army march along, if the path they follow vanishes, swallowed by shifting earth or by the illusion of clouds that hide the sun? How can the knight strike against his enemy, if the man he calls comrade turns against him in a single heartbeat, or if his foe wears the guise of his closest friend? How can the hero save the people, if he has been tricked into serving the villain, his hands carrying doom instead of deliverance? How can the king rule his kingdom, when daggers glint in the dark, and even the crown seems to shift upon his head, heavier or lighter with the whispering of invisible hands? How could a god kill Venith, if he does not even know where or what he is?

Venith's lies were deep, his plans wild and twisting, and sometimes he himself no longer seemed to know the truth from the lies. Any potential new gods, any challengers who might rise against him, he could guide toward ruin, bend toward failure, or snuff out before they were even aware of their destiny. He could play with them, as he could play with all things now — all bending, dancing, faltering — obeying his unseen hand.

But why?

Some say his very nature was twisted from the start, forged by Aster himself, a creature born to lie, a loyal servant who could never stray from the shadow of his master. Some say that he saw the rise of the New Gods, and greed, ambition, and desire for dominion consumed him, and he took it all for himself. Some say he loved betrayal, the thrill of deceit, the shaping of chaos as an artist shapes clay, and trust was a concept forever foreign to him. Some say the immense power he gathered drove him insane, unraveling the line between truth and illusion, until the world itself stopped making any sense.

Whatever the case, this is the true story of Venith the Trickster God. He who made the world tremble, he who bent mortals and immortals alike, he who spun the web of chaos so wide that none could escape. He who ended the first age. This was the grand lie he spoke, and woe to those to whom he still speaks.

I attest this is true by my name, Spell, the First.

— Spell, *Venith's Grand Lie*